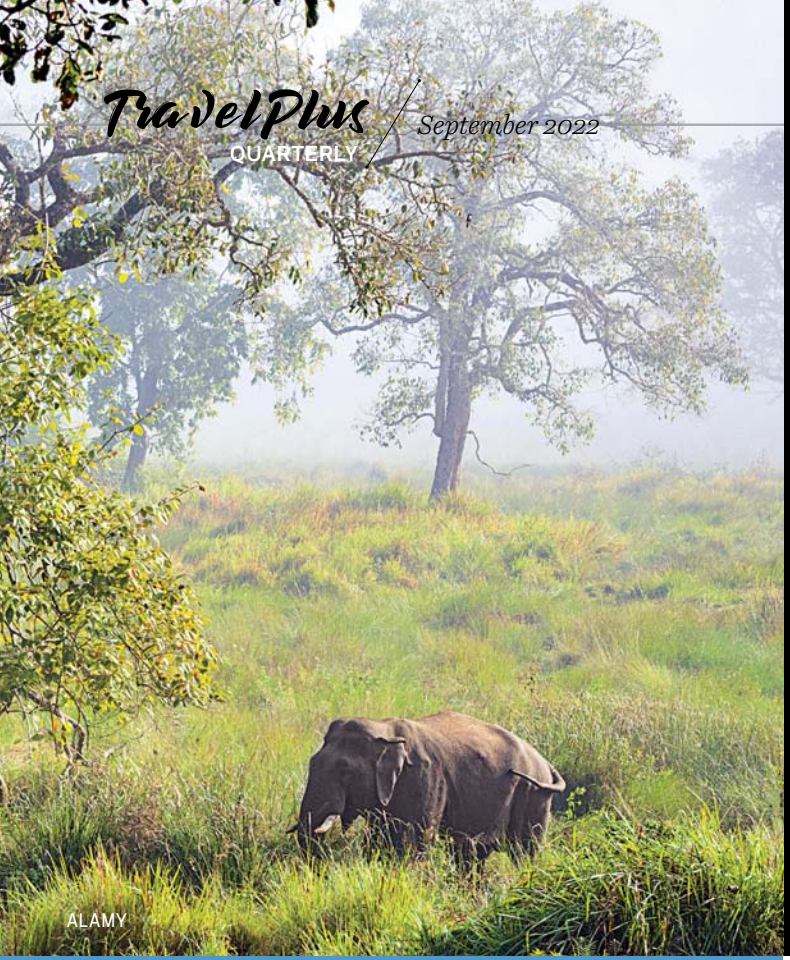


ALAMY

Nagarhole National Park, Karnataka

One of India's oldest national parks, Nagarhole has grown in popularity of late, thanks to active media coverage of its leopard population, especially Saya, its famous 'black panther' (a colloquialism for a melanistic leopard that is often sighted in the area). But it isn't just these graceful felines that prowl its dhindal and teak forests—elephants, sambar, and gaurs enjoy a healthy population density. Guides and jeeps can be booked at the park entrance, along with a minibus safari, which the forest department conducts twice daily. Nagarhole and Kabini are used interchangeably these days, but the latter actually refers to a reserve forest towards the south of the national park, and lies in the catchment area of the river Kabini. The best way to explore the Kabini backwaters is via a boat safari, but jeeps might be a better choice during the colder months.

WATCH OUT FOR
Packs of dholes—tenacious and ferocious wild dogs that are capable of punching above their weight in the forest

VISIT
October onwards, when the temperature is just right and sightings are easier to be had

Marine National Park, Gujarat

India is home to six marine national parks dedicated to conservation and raising awareness about aquatic life. In Gujarat, an hour and a half west of Jamnagar, along the Gulf of Kutch, India's oldest such nature reserve stretches over an archipelago of over 40 islands. The habitat, an extensive mangrove system, supports over 50 coral species, 70 sponge species, intriguing algae and more than 400 bird species such as painted stork and black-necked ibis. The 163 sq. km park is accessible from Jamnagar via boat, and at Narara Reef, visitors can explore the seabed on foot and come face to face with the colourful marine life that thrives here, including octopuses, sea cucumbers, wolf crabs and the like. Requisite permits and guides are available at the Narara Forest Office.

WATCH OUT FOR
The puffer fish, an intriguing marine specimen whose defence mechanism against any kind of threat is to inflate itself

VISIT
November onwards, when temperatures are on their way down in the region



SHUTTERSTOCK

Namdapha National Park, Arunachal Pradesh

One of India's largest national parks, Namdapha is a near-impermeable zone of remoteness straddling several habitats across elevations, in Arunachal's easternmost district, Changlang. This highly biodiverse nature reserve is the stomping ground of a number of large mammals, including elephants, leopards (common, snow and clouded), and tigers. While sighting these illustrious residents might not be always possible (particularly tigers, which reside in the core area), Namdapha is an excellent choice to get as close as possible to nature. After all, these forests boast several rare species of butterflies (including red caliph and koh-i-noor), close to 500 avian species such as snowy-throated babblers, golden-crested mynas, and pallid harriers, and some really rare orchid variants, which also make it a botanical haven. The forest department operates five designated campsites and a forest rest house, but bookings must be made well in advance.

WATCH OUT FOR
The hoolock gibbon, India's only ape that is found only in Namdapha and Assam's Hollongapar Gibbon Sanctuary

VISIT
Late October onwards